

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Ezra

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Ezra tells how God brought many Israelites back to Jerusalem after 70 years of exile in Babylon. The people had to resist false worship, rebuild the temple, and turn away from sin. Some had chosen to follow the values of the world instead of God's ways. In Ezra, we see that God provides for and protects those who trust him and obey his word.

Setting

About 130 years before Ezra came to Jerusalem in 458 BC, God punished Judah because the people continued to do evil. He sent the Babylonians to destroy Jerusalem, tear down the temple, and take thousands of people into exile (see 2 Kings 25:1-30).

While the Israelites lived in exile in Babylon, they could build homes, plant gardens, and live fairly well. They also had some freedom to worship God (Jeremiah 29:4-5). Some Israelites even received places of power and honor (Daniel 3 and 6).

God had promised to bring his people back to the holy land after 70 years (2 Chronicles 36:21; Jeremiah 25:12; 29:10). Around 559 BC, the Persian prince Cyrus II defeated the Medes and joined their kingdom to his own. This became the Persian Empire. Then, in 539 BC, the Persians defeated the Babylonians. This made the way for God's promise to be fulfilled. In 538 BC, Cyrus began to let the Jewish people leave Babylon. Sheshbazzar led the first group of exiles back to their homeland (Ezra 1:1-8).

When the people of Israel and Judah were taken to foreign lands, the Assyrians and Babylonians moved other conquered peoples into the land of Israel. When the Jewish exiles returned, they found these peoples living in the land they wanted to rebuild.

These people said they worshiped the same God as the Jews. But their religion mixed Jewish beliefs and practices with pagan worship. They wanted to worship with the returning Jews. The Jews saw that this would weaken their faithfulness to God (4:3). So they refused to let these people take part in their community.

Because of this, the Jewish community faced strong opposition from the people living in the land. This choice led to many years of conflict. It also delayed the rebuilding of the temple. But the exile had taught the Jews an important lesson. If they mixed their faith with false worship, the result would be even worse.

Several decades later, Ezra came to Jerusalem. He found that some Israelites had weakened their faithfulness to God by marrying foreign women (9:1-2). God had clearly forbidden these marriages because they would lead the Israelites to follow pagan worship (Deuteronomy 7:3-4; Joshua 23:12-13). This sin would bring God's judgment unless the people confessed it and corrected it (9:13-15; 10:14). Ezra led the people to separate themselves from pagan influence and renew their covenant (a binding agreement) with God (10:1-11).

Timeline of Events in Ezra

Ezra tells about events in Judah from 538 to about 450 BC.

538-536 BC

After Cyrus commanded that the Jews could return to their homeland, about 50,000 people left for Jerusalem (1:1-4). There they restored the Jewish community, built a new altar (1:5-3:6), and began to rebuild the temple (3:7-13). These Jews refused to weaken their faith by joining with local people who did not worship God faithfully. Soon, these local people opposed them and stopped the rebuilding work (4:1-5).

520-515 BC

Almost 20 years later, God used the prophets Haggai and Zechariah to call his people to continue rebuilding the temple (5:1-6:12). The Jews obeyed. With support from Persia, they finished the temple in 515 BC. No one stopped the work again (see also Haggai 1:2-6; Zechariah 4:9; 6:12-15; 8:9).

486-445 BC

The Jews encountered opposition when they first tried to rebuild the city and its walls (Ezra 4:6-23).

458 BC

Ezra traveled to Jerusalem to lead the people and oversee government matters (7:1-26). He learned that some Israelites were not obeying the law of Moses. They had married unbelievers and had made Israel unclean before God.

Ezra prayed and asked God for mercy. Then he led an official investigation. Many Israelites repented of their sins and divorced their pagan wives (9:1-10:44).

445 BC

Nehemiah came to Jerusalem and rebuilt the city walls. He completed the work even though many people opposed him and caused trouble (see Nehemiah 1-7).

Author

Traditionally, people treated Ezra and Nehemiah as one book written by Ezra. As a scribe, Ezra would have had access to many official documents included in the book.

Some people also believe Ezra wrote Chronicles. They point out that the last verses of 2 Chronicles are very similar to the first verses of Ezra (compare 2 Chronicles 36:22–23 and Ezra 1:1–3). They also note that the books use some of the same words and share similar ideas about God.

However, many scholars reject this view. They argue that Chronicles and Ezra–Nehemiah have greater differences in language and theology than similarities.

Language and Sources

Most of the Old Testament was written in Hebrew. But the book of Ezra includes two sections written in Aramaic, the common language of the Persian Empire (4:8–6:18 and 7:12–26). The six official documents in these sections are:

- Rehum's letter to King Artaxerxes (4:8–16),
- Artaxerxes's letter to Rehum (4:17–22),
- Tattenai's letter to King Darius (5:6–17),
- Cyrus's decree to build the temple in Jerusalem (6:3–5),
- Darius's letter to Tattenai (6:6–12), and
- Artaxerxes's letter to Ezra (7:12–26).

These documents appear to be authentic, or historically reliable. This helps support the historical truth of Ezra's account.

Ezra also includes several documents written in Hebrew. These include:

- the decree of Cyrus (1:2–4);
- a list of temple objects (1:9–11);
- a list of the Israelites who first returned to Jerusalem (2:1–69);
- a list of those who returned with Ezra (8:1–14);
- a list of treasures Ezra brought to Jerusalem (8:26–27); and
- a list of the men who divorced pagan wives (10:18–44).

These lists helped assure the Jewish people that Ezra kept careful records. Only the original holy objects would be used in the temple. Only those on the official list of Israelites could worship at the temple. Only the men who divorced pagan wives would remain among God's holy people.

By including these details, Ezra showed great care in separating what was holy from what was not holy.

Meaning and Message

God's people felt helpless when they returned to Jerusalem after exile in Babylon. They faced danger from robbers on the long trip home. In Jerusalem, nearby people opposed them. They could not control the decisions of the Persian government. They also had the huge task of rebuilding a ruined nation. How could they follow God when so much was outside their control?

Ezra explains four key themes that show how God carries out his will in the lives of his people.

1. God rules over Israel's history. Everything that happens in Ezra shows God's sovereign control. This means God rules over all things and carries out his purposes.

God inspired Cyrus to let the Jews return to Jerusalem after 70 years of exile (Ezra 1:1–4). God also promised that treasures from other nations would come to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple (Haggai 2:7–8). This happened because God “turned the heart of the king of Assyria toward them” (Ezra 6:6–12, 6:22).

Later, when Ezra came to Jerusalem, God inspired Artaxerxes to give Ezra everything he needed (Ezra 7:6). God also protected the Jews from attack as they traveled to Jerusalem (8:22, 31). Ezra knew that God controlled the future of the nation (9:6–15). Only a believer who is convinced that God is sovereign over this world will be able to remain faithful to God in the midst of conflict, difficulty, and discouragement.

1. God's people must remain pure and separate from sin in this world. Ezra was a priest from Aaron's family line (Ezra 7:1–5). He strongly believed that God's people must remain separate from sin and false worship. The first Jews who returned to Jerusalem believed this too. They refused to work with the local pagan people (4:1–5). This caused many years of trouble and conflict. But the people knew they could not weaken the purity of their faith and still remain faithful to God.

When Ezra later came to Jerusalem, he saw that many people were not living this way (9:1–2). Ezra understood that this was a serious crisis (9:3–15). He led the people to renew their covenant with God and to separate themselves from pagan influence (10:1–11).

1. Obeying God's word is very important. As a scribe, Ezra was committed to studying and obeying God's law. He also taught it to others (7:10). Ezra often explained his decisions by pointing to God's instructions in Scripture. The king of Persia had told Ezra

to teach and enforce the law of Moses (7:14, 23–25). That is exactly what Ezra did (for example, 8:35; 9:1–10:17).

2. Prayer for others invites God's compassion and power. Ezra's prayer of confession shows humility as he asked God for grace (9:6–15). Ezra knew that a strong sermon against the people might not move them to repent. So he tore his clothes, wept, and mourned over the nation's sin. God used Ezra's confession to touch the people's hearts. Many people repented and returned to God (9:6–10:17).

Earlier, Ezra had also fasted and prayed for safety on the journey to Jerusalem. He knew that only God could protect them from attack (8:21–23, 31–32).